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The Journal of American History March 2006 The history of slavery has largely been a history of fields—tobacco, sugar, indigo, rice, and cotton fields. The most influential works on slavery have properly focused on agricultural bondage and how it shaped slavery's development and defined the majority of owner-slave relationships. A few historians, such as Richard Price, W. Jeffrey Bolster, David S. Cecelski, Michael Craton, and Tomas Buchanan, have studied maritime slavery, the work of enslaved people in sailing, fishing, and whaling.² A handful of scholars have mentioned slaves as swimmers, but there has been no sustained study of their recreational and occupational swimming and underwater diving.³ Although most bondpeople were agricultural laborers, that did not preclude swimming. Most plantations were located near waterways to facilitate the transportation of slave-produced goods to market, and rice plantations throughout the Americas were typically situated on tidal waterways, which were vital to the irrigation of this crop.⁴ Thus, large numbers of plantation slaves had ready access to waters in which to swim. Since the mid-twentieth century, scholars have increasingly appreciated slaves' ability to transmit African skills and practices to the Americas and have examined how cultural retentions shaped the development of both black and white sociocultural institutions. Poetry, as Reading Exercises for the Younger Children in the Schools and Families of the Confederate States (Richmond, 1864), 20–21; William Percey, The Compleat Swimmer; or, The art of Swimming: Demonstrating the Rules and Practice Thereof, in an Exact, Plain and Easie Method. 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To which is Prefixed a Prefatory Discourse Concerning Artificial Swimming, or Keeping ones self Above Water by Several small Portable Engines, in case of Danger (London, 1699), i–viii, 1, 4–5. 2 Richard Price, "Caribbean Fishing and Fishermen: A Historical Sketch," American Anthropologist, 68 (Dec. 1966), 1363–83; James Farr, "A Slow Boat to Nowhere: The Multi-Racial Crews of the American Whaling Industry," Journal of Negro History, 68 (Spring 1983), 159–70; W. Jeffrey Bolster, Black Jacks: African American Seamen in the Age of Sail (Cambridge, Mass., 1997), 10; David S. 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